

THE LANTERN IN THE STORM

A Five-Part Moral Story

Page 1 — The Village Without Light

At the edge of a green valley stood a small village called Velanur. The village was surrounded by rice fields, tamarind trees, and a narrow river that glittered under the afternoon sun. The people were hardworking, but they often argued about one thing: who was responsible for helping the village when trouble came.

Among them lived a seventeen-year-old boy named Arun. He was clever, but he had one weakness. He wanted everyone to notice him. Whenever there was work to be done, Arun was quick to explain what others should do, but he was rarely the first to pick up a tool himself.

One evening, dark clouds gathered over the valley. The wind grew stronger, and thunder rolled across the hills. The village elders warned everyone to stay indoors because a violent storm was approaching.

As night fell, the electricity suddenly failed. The village became completely dark.

“We cannot see anything!” people shouted.

“The river may overflow!”

“Who will check the old bridge?”

Arun stepped outside holding a small oil lantern. He looked around and saw frightened families standing in their doorways.

“I will go and check the bridge,” he announced.

A few villagers laughed. “You? You are always giving orders. Why should we believe you?”

Arun felt embarrassed. For once, nobody was impressed by his words.

Then he noticed an old woman, Meenakshi, struggling to carry a sack of rice into her house. Without saying anything, Arun put down his lantern, lifted the sack, and carried it inside.

“Thank you,” she said quietly.

When Arun returned outside, he realized that the lantern was still burning. Its flame was small, but it was enough to illuminate a few steps around him.

He thought about the storm. One small flame could not light the entire village. But it could

help one person find the next step.

Arun decided that instead of trying to become the village hero, he would simply do whatever useful thing was in front of him.

He picked up the lantern and walked toward the bridge.

Page 2 — The Broken Bridge

The path to the river was slippery. Rain poured down, and the wind bent the trees until their branches seemed to touch the ground. Arun held the lantern close to his chest and moved carefully.

When he reached the bridge, he discovered that part of the wooden railing had broken. Worse, the river was rising quickly.

Arun knew that children sometimes crossed the bridge early in the morning to reach school. If the damage was not repaired before dawn, someone could fall into the river.

He ran back toward the village.

“We need rope, wooden boards, and tools!” he shouted.

This time, instead of giving orders, he asked for help.

The carpenter brought a hammer. A farmer brought strong rope. Two young women carried wooden planks. Meenakshi arrived with hot tea for everyone.

Even the people who had laughed at Arun came to help.

They worked for hours in the rain. Nobody received a prize. Nobody stood on a stage. They simply worked because the bridge needed to be made safe.

At one point, Arun saw the carpenter struggling to hold a heavy plank.

“Let me help,” Arun said.

Together they lifted it into place.

Near midnight, the bridge was stable enough for people to cross safely.

The villagers stood silently for a moment, listening to the river.

“We did it,” someone finally said.

Arun looked at the lantern in his hand.

Its oil was almost finished.

The old woman Meenakshi smiled at him. “Do you know why that lantern was useful?”

“Because it was bright?” Arun guessed.

“No,” she replied. “Because someone carried it.”

Arun thought about her words.

A lantern sitting on a shelf could give light to nobody. Its value came from being carried into the darkness.

The storm continued through the night, but the village was no longer helpless. People checked on their neighbors, moved animals to higher ground, and shared food with families whose homes had flooded.

Arun realized something important: leadership was not about being the person everyone praised. It was about being willing to take responsibility when nobody else wanted to.

Just before dawn, the rain finally began to weaken.

But the greatest challenge was still ahead.

Page 3 — The Missing Child

At sunrise, the villagers discovered that the river had flooded several fields. Mud covered the roads, and fallen branches blocked the paths.

Then a mother came running through the village.

“My daughter! Kavya is missing!”

Everyone froze.

Kavya was eight years old. She had gone to her grandmother's house the previous evening, but she had never arrived.

The villagers immediately formed groups to search.

Arun remembered that Kavya loved watching the river from a small hill beyond the mango orchard. He took his lantern, though daylight had already arrived, and started toward the hill.

Halfway there, he heard a faint cry.

“Kavya!”

He followed the sound and found her trapped near a muddy ditch. She had slipped while trying to cross a flooded path. She was frightened and unable to climb out.

“Don't move,” Arun called. “I'll get help.”

He ran back.

A strong farmer came with a rope. The carpenter brought a long bamboo pole. Together, they pulled Kavya to safety.

Her mother hugged her tightly, crying with relief.

Arun stood nearby, covered in mud.

The villagers began praising him.

“You found her!”

“You saved her!”

“You are our hero!”

For a moment, Arun felt proud. Then he remembered the broken bridge, the carpenter, the

farmer, Meenakshi, and all the others who had helped.

“I didn't do it alone,” he said. “Everyone helped.”

The village elder nodded.

“That is the lesson of the storm. A person may carry the lantern, but many hands keep the light alive.”

Later that afternoon, the villagers gathered in the square. They counted the damage and began planning repairs.

Arun was surprised when the elder asked him to help organize the work.

“But I'm not the strongest person here,” Arun said.

“You don't need to be,” replied the elder. “You learned to listen. That is more useful than giving orders.”

Arun accepted the responsibility.

From that day onward, he stopped trying to prove that he was important. Instead, he tried to make himself useful.

He learned to ask questions before giving answers.

He learned to thank people.

And most importantly, he learned that doing good work quietly was often more valuable than receiving applause.

Page 4 — The Second Storm

Several weeks passed. Velanur slowly returned to normal. The bridge was repaired properly, the damaged houses were rebuilt, and the fields began to recover.

Arun's behavior had changed. He still had ambition, but now he understood that ambition without responsibility was empty.

One evening, the village received another warning. A second storm was approaching.

This time, everyone remembered the previous disaster.

The villagers did not wait for someone to tell them what to do. Farmers moved their animals. Families stored drinking water. The carpenter checked the bridge. Young people cleared the drainage channels.

Arun walked from house to house with a list.

“Is everyone safe?”

“Does anyone need medicine?”

“Which families need help moving their belongings?”

He was no longer trying to be the hero. He was trying to make sure nobody was forgotten.

During the night, the storm became fierce.

A large tree fell across the road, trapping several families on the far side of the village.

Arun and the others worked together to clear a narrow path.

Then the electricity went out again.

Someone brought the old lantern from the village hall.

Arun recognized it immediately.

It was the same lantern he had carried during the first storm.

Its glass was scratched, and its metal handle was bent, but it still worked.

Meenakshi handed it to him.

“Take it,” she said.

Arun shook his head. “Someone else should carry it.”

She smiled. “Then choose someone who needs the light.”

Arun looked around.

A young boy named Selvam was standing nearby, nervous and unsure what to do.

“Selvam,” Arun said, “will you carry the lantern while we clear the road?”

The boy's eyes widened.

“Me?”

“Yes. You don't need to be strong. Just keep the light where people can see it.”

Selvam took the lantern.

For the next two hours, he walked beside the workers, lighting their path.

When the storm finally passed, Selvam realized that he had helped the village.

He smiled.

Arun smiled too.

The lantern had taught him its final lesson: sometimes the best thing a leader can do is give someone else the chance to become useful.

By morning, the village was safe.

The second storm had been stronger than the first.

Yet the people were less afraid.

They had learned that courage becomes powerful when it is shared.

Page 5 — The Light We Carry

Years later, Arun became the head of the village council. People respected him, not because he was the loudest person in the room, but because he listened carefully and kept his promises.

The old lantern remained in the village hall.

Whenever children asked about it, the elders told them the story of the two storms.

They explained how one boy had once believed that leadership meant being admired.

Then they told them how he learned that real leadership meant serving others.

One evening, many years after the first storm, Arun stood outside the village hall. A group of children were preparing for a school play about Velanur's history.

One child pointed at the lantern.

“Is this the famous lantern?”

Arun laughed.

“It isn't famous because of the lantern itself.”

“Then why?”

“Because of what people did while carrying it.”

The child thought for a moment.

“So the lantern saved the village?”

“No,” Arun said. “People saved the village. The lantern only helped them see where to step.”

The children became quiet.

Arun looked toward the river. The bridge stood strong in the moonlight.

He remembered the night when he had first walked toward it, hoping to prove himself.

He had gone looking for a chance to become a hero.

Instead, he had discovered something much better: a reason to help.

The village had taught him that a small act of kindness can begin something much larger. A person who helps one neighbor may inspire another. That person may inspire ten more. Soon,

an entire community can become stronger—not because one person is extraordinary, but because ordinary people choose to care for one another.

Arun returned the lantern to its place.

Its flame was small.

But its meaning was enormous.

Moral

True leadership is not about standing above others; it is about helping others stand strong. Even a small act of kindness can become a great light when people choose to share it.

And so the lantern remained in Velanur—not as a symbol of one hero, but as a reminder that in every storm, we can choose to carry a little light for someone else.